

JUDGE



SALARY

Administrative law judge ★★★★★
Supreme Court justice ★★★★★

INDUSTRY PROFILE

Fierce competition for open positions •
Most jobs open only after a current
judge finishes his or her term or retires •
Length of appointments vary

JOB DESCRIPTION

With infallible knowledge of the law and excellent research, writing, and decision-making skills, judges preside over and ensure fairness within courtrooms. Judges are employed by local, state, and federal governments to oversee a variety of cases, both civil and criminal. A highly sought-after role in the law profession, most judges are elected or appointed into their positions.



AT A GLANCE



YOUR INTERESTS Law • Research and writing • English • History • Psychology • Sociology • Criminology • Politics • Decision-making



ENTRY QUALIFICATIONS A law degree is required for most judgeships. Some appointments are available for non-lawyers, but opportunities are scarce.



LIFESTYLE Judges typically work regular office hours, depending on the requirements of the court. Overtime hours spent researching are common.



LOCATION Judges spend the majority of their working hours in an office, at law libraries or research centers, or in the courtroom.



THE REALITIES Research hours are long. The work is often intellectually demanding, requiring a very thorough understanding of the details.

CAREER PATHS

GRADUATE There are some hearing officer and administrative law judge positions available to those without a law degree. However, these opportunities are scarce and often filled by candidates with higher law qualifications.

LAW SCHOOL GRADUATE The most common route to becoming a judge is to graduate from an accredited law school and pass a state's bar exam, qualifying you to practice as a lawyer.

